

Beachcomber

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I am a beachcomber. Beachcombers are all different, of course, but I think most of those I've met would call me an eccentric.

Dedicated beachcombers (perhaps "professional" is too strong a word) search for driftwood or detritus which might be useful or attractive or valuable. Amateurs search for souvenirs like pretty stones. Children are enchanted by the idea of a message in a bottle, but will pick up anything. Me, I'm interested in one thing only: poetry.

There's a kind of loose camaraderie among beachcombers. We don't often encounter each other - it tends to be a solitary pursuit. But when we do, the talk is of what we've found, where we found it, and perhaps where we've stashed it, though that is often a secret. Someone told me about finding a splintered piece of wood with the letters CHRI carved on it. The wood was broken at that point, so it might have originally read Christ or Christopher or Christine, you couldn't tell. I wondered if it could have been Christina, and told him I had just the previous day found a fragment of Christina Rossetti's *Goblin Market*. He looked at me strangely and did not reply. Most beachcombers are not much interested in poetry.

Fragments are all you tend to find on the beach. A line, or perhaps two. Sometimes all you get is one word, but it's always clear which poem it's from. A falling tide and a light onshore breeze are the most productive conditions, but there's no guarantee of finding anything.

I have collected some wonderful things over the years. The romantics, of course, particularly Coleridge, have often featured. I have a few words of Blake's, and some early Hardy. Among the moderns, I have found scraps of Hughes and Plath, and one line of Larkin's - a favourite in my collection.

Sometimes you have to travel to find what you want. Hoping for some Norman McCaig, I visited Assynt, and discovered quite a few useful fragments. There was a welcome bonus: on the stiff Atlantic wind, blowing in from the New World, I snared a couplet of Emily Dickinson's and a beautiful

line of Whitman's.

It doesn't always work, though. A few years ago I roamed the coast of Spurn Bay, hoping to collect some more Larkin. Nothing turned up, apart from - to my astonishment and dismay - a line by William McGonagall, which of course I left there. The whole thing was a complete waste of time.

Though I enjoy travelling, there's no real need to go traipsing round the country. Quite often, I seek out a small beach, not far from where I live. If it is deserted, as it usually is, I slowly meander along looking at the water, restless and grey, slapping on the shingle. The *allegretto* of the waves and the *vivace* of the wind are charged with meaning; the fragments make themselves known and I squirrel them away. *Wine-dark* emerged majestically, and I shivered to feel Homer's breath on my cheek.

All beachcombers are, by definition, recycling enthusiasts. Re-using or re-purposing what others have discarded is our passion. I have enjoyed putting these scraps to use - good use, I hope, though that is for others to say. Patchwork poems, constructed from scraps glued together with hope and judgement, have occupied my weather-bound winter evenings. It pleases me to share these recondite attempts, and to my surprise they sell reasonably well at the local craft markets in the summer, amidst stalls of pokerwork, wood-turning, baked goods and twee knitted dolls.

It was inevitable, I suppose, that some of my fragments should turn up on the beach once more. The first recycled line I found was originally by Mary Oliver, but I had re-used it just a few months earlier in a patchwork poem. The morsel I found was clearly from my poem, not the original. It was a bit of a shock at the time, but after a while I began to understand that all poetry is, in a sense, the re-use of words.

It was about about a year ago that I started to notice the change. It became increasingly difficult to find poetry along the beach. Most days I came away with nothing. Finding the slightest scrap became a cause of celebration. I remember the delight I felt at catching half a line by Clive James, something which I might have disdained just a few months previously. I would even have welcomed - grudgingly - a fragment of McGonagall.

But I had my collection to enjoy. Then it too started to disappear. Very

slowly, the words started to fade, gradually dissolving, letter by letter, into a grey mist, a smudge, and then vanishing entirely. I was, for a while, inconsolable.

Today, I have come to terms with how my life has changed. I am still a beachcomber, but in a desultory fashion, picking up discarded fishing floats, bits of plastic, fragments of frayed nylon rope. I mourn the loss of poetry, but I am buoyed up by the one fragment that remains to me, the oldest of all, unfaded and as pristine as the day it was written. οἶνοψ πόντος (oînops pónτος) - the wine-dark sea.